

Pharmacists & Sorcerers

they have more in common than you want to believe

Where the English word Pharmacy comes from is really quite simple. But, what's more fascinating is how the root from Ancient Greek is used in Scripture and how it is directly linked both **linguistically** (where the word came from and how it's used) and **practically** (what the people do that it describes and the products they produce) to things we see today ([Ecc 1:9](#)).

Historical Stage	Word	Language Type
Original Root	φαρμακεία (<i>pharmakeia</i>)	Ancient Greek
Direct Ancestor	<i>pharmacia</i>	Late / Medieval Latin
Middle Step	<i>farmacie</i>	Old / Middle French
Modern Word	<i>Pharmacy</i>	Modern English

Strong's numbers connected to Pharmacy through the Greek root^{*}:

G5331 (pharmakeia) (derived from G5332)	Gal 5:20 Idolatry, witchcraft^{G5331}, hatred, variance, emulations, wrath, strife, seditions, heresies, Rev 9:21 Neither repented they of their murders, nor of their sorceries^{G5331}, nor of their fornication, nor of their thefts. Rev 18:23 And the light of a candle shall shine no more at all in thee; and the voice of the bridegroom and of the bride shall be heard no more at all in thee: for thy merchants were the great men of the earth; for by thy sorceries^{G5331} were all nations deceived.
G5332 (pharmakeus)	Rev 21:8 But the fearful, and unbelieving, and the abominable, and murderers, and whoremongers, and sorcerers^{G5332}, and idolaters, and all liars, shall have their part in the lake which burneth with fire and brimstone: which is the second death.
G5333 (pharmakos)	Rev 22:15 For without are dogs, and sorcerers^{G5333}, and whoremongers, and murderers, and idolaters, and whosoever loveth and maketh a lie.

Even if there was no practical connection, who wants to be linguistically associated with Sorcerers and Witches? That's the very essence of the error of Balaam (mixing godliness with worldliness). He tried to have one foot in each world and where did that get him ([Jos 13:22](#); and an example of what **not** to do)? God demands holiness ([1Pet 1:15,16](#)) and will have none of the idolatry of *pharmakeis* (plural of *pharmakeus*).

Summary of cultural usage		
Strong's Number	Greek Word	Cultural Function & Usage
G5331	<i>pharmakeia</i>	The <i>act</i> of administering potions, ranging from legitimate medical purging to illegal poisoning and occult spell-casting.
G5332	<i>pharmakeus</i>	The <i>artisan/mixer</i> who physically understands how to extract, boil, and compound potent substances for drugs or magic.
G5333	<i>pharmakos</i>	The <i>sorcerer or scapegoat</i> ; an individual spiritually marked by the deceptive, corrupting use of occult arts and illicit substances.

Common/cultural usage

Those three Greek roots* used in scripture are built upon the word φάρμακον (pharmakon). To the ancient Greek mind a *pharmakon* was simply “a potent substance capable of altering the physical or mental state”. It is neutral on its own and could either heal or kill. In order to form the three root words* above that we see in the Bible, *pharmakon* had suffixes added to it that each add their own nuances.

φαρμακεία (pharmakeia)

- The suffix -eia denotes an action, activity, or the business/practice.
- In common civic life it meant “the administration or employment of drugs and potions”.
 - Medicinal application
 - Poisoning
 - Spiritual/occult manipulation
 - The word became synonymous with casting spells and trafficking with spirits (*familiar spirits*).

φαρμακεύς (pharmakeus)

- The suffix -eus denotes a specific agent, trade practitioner, or craftsman (like a silversmith or a blacksmith).
- In common usage it meant “the person who physically compounded and mixed the potions”.
- If you went into an ancient marketplace, this person was essentially a “druggist” or an “apothecary.” However, because there was no strict division between science and the supernatural back then, a *pharmakeus* wasn't just a pharmacist in the modern sense. They were often viewed with a degree of suspicion - someone who knew how to boil down roots to make a fever go away but who also knew how to mix a deadly odorless poison, create a “love potion,” or brew a narcotic drink for a pagan ritual.

φάρμακος (pharmakos)

- The suffix -os turns *pharmakon* into an adjective denoting something “devoted to” or “belonging to” the drug/potion craft, used as a masculine noun.
- Used more broadly to describe “the practitioner of the dark/magical side of the craft”.
- *Pharmakos* carries a very dark, specific cultural history in classical Greek. In ancient Athens and Marseilles during times of plague or famine, the city would select an outcast, a criminal, or a physically deformed person. This person was called the *pharmakos*. They were fed at public expense, paraded through the city to “absorb” its spiritual pollution, and then cast out of the city or executed as a human scapegoat to “purge” the community. Therefore, to a native Greek ear, *pharmakos* always carried an underlying connotation of spiritual filth, an outcast, or a malicious worker of dark/corrupting arts.

We can use the English to easily bridge between the NT and the OT.

H3784	Exo 7:11 Then Pharaoh also called the wise men and the sorcerers^{H3784}: now the magicians of Egypt, they also did in like manner with their enchantments. Exo 22:18 Thou shalt not suffer a witch^{H3784} to live. Deu 18:10 There shall not be found among you any one that maketh his son or his daughter to pass through the fire, or that useth divination, or an observer of times, or an enchanter, or a witch^{H3784}, 2Ch 33:6 And he caused his children to pass through the fire in the valley of the son of Hinnom: also he observed times, and used enchantments, and used witchcraft^{H3784}, and dealt with a familiar spirit, and with wizards: he wrought much evil in the sight of the LORD, to provoke him to anger. Dan 2:2 Then the king commanded to call the magicians, and the astrologers, and the sorcerers^{H3784}, and the Chaldeans, for to shew the king his dreams. So they came and stood before the king. Mal 3:5 And I will come near to you to judgment; and I will be a swift witness against the sorcerers^{H3784}, and against the adulterers, and against false swearers, and against those that oppress the hireling in his wages, the widow, and the fatherless, and that turn aside the stranger from his right, and fear not me, saith the LORD of hosts.
H3785	2Ki 9:22 And it came to pass, when Joram saw Jehu, that he said, Is it peace, Jehu? And he answered, What peace, so long as the whoredoms of thy mother Jezebel and her witchcrafts^{H3785} are so many? Isa 47:9 But these two things shall come to thee in a moment in one day, the loss of children, and widowhood: they shall come upon thee in their perfection for the multitude of thy sorceries^{H3785}, and for the great abundance of thine enchantments. Isa 47:12 Stand now with thine enchantments, and with the multitude of thy sorceries^{H3785}, wherein thou hast laboured from thy youth; if so be thou shalt be able to profit, if so be thou mayest prevail. Mic 5:12 And I will cut off witchcrafts^{H3785} out of thine hand; and thou shalt have no more soothsayers: Nah 3:4 Because of the multitude of the whoredoms of the wellfavoured harlot, the mistress of witchcrafts^{H3785}, that selleth nations through her whoredoms, and families through her witchcrafts^{H3785}.
H3786	Jer 27:9 Therefore hearken not ye to your prophets, nor to your diviners, nor to your dreamers, nor to your enchanters, nor to your sorcerers^{H3786}, which speak unto you, saying, Ye shall not serve the king of Babylon:

Knowing all of this it becomes undeniable that through not only the linguistic etymology but also the evolution of the common, cultural uses of the variations of *pharmakon* there are direct links to both the words and practices we still see today:

Modern equivalent	Greek word
Pharmacies (the place where drugs are trafficked)	G5331 φαρμακεία (pharmakeia)
Pharmaceuticals (the drugs themselves)	Φάρμακον (pharmakon/pharmaka)
Pharmacist (linguistic match) Pharmaceutical scientist (the people who mix/create the drugs)	G5332 Φαρμακεύς (pharmakeus)
(commonly) Scapegoat (sociological & clinical literature) "The Pharmakos Complex" or simply referring to a targeted individual in a group as "the pharmakos"	G5333 φάρμακος (pharmakos)

While the others are self-evident the connection to the modern "Scapegoat" / G5333 might require a little more explanation:

1. The Practical Connection (The Ritual)

In ancient Greece, the *pharmakos* was not just a sorcerer; he was a living lightning rod for collective guilt. When a city faced a crisis it could not control—like a plague, famine, or military invasion—the community experienced massive internal anxiety and friction.

To restore order, they did not look for a rational or scientific solution. Instead, they chose an outcast (the *pharmakos*), transferred all the "spiritual pollution" and blame of the city onto his head, and violently cast him out or executed him. The moment the *pharmakos* was banished, the community felt an immediate, psychological sense of relief and unity.

This is the exact definition of scapegoating. In modern psychology, sociology, and politics, a "*pharmakos*" or scapegoat is a person or minority group selected by a stressed community to bear the blame for a crisis they didn't cause, purely to relieve the community's internal tension.

2. The Linguistic Evolution

While the English word "scapegoat" comes from a translation choice in the Hebrew Old Testament (the *ez ozel* or "goat of departure" in [Leviticus 16](#)), Western sociological and psychological frameworks heavily **preserve** the literal Greek word *pharmakos* to describe this exact phenomenon.

Anthropologists and literary critics use the term "The Pharmakos Archetype" to describe:

- A character in literature who is innocent but must die or be exiled so society can survive (eg. Shirley Jackson's short story *The Lottery*).
- The Office Pharmakos: A modern workplace dynamic where a failing corporate team unconsciously selects one worker to blame for all missed deadlines, convincing themselves that firing that one person will fix the entire company culture.

Now, in order to further bridge the gap between the Bible and modern day all we have to do is take the obvious connections to the words and put them together with the practical application of the Biblical words.

Seemingly, “pharmacies” and “pharmaceutical scientists” did not exist in “Biblical” times (quotes because Revelation is specifically talking about the time we’re living in right now). But, they actually did exist back then, they just went by different names. Even though the names aren’t the same we can still easily connect them together them by their **practices** (what they do and how they live).

There’s a simple example in scripture that we see going on every day around us. If only we would stop and think things through more carefully.

Mark 5:25-34

²⁵ And a certain woman, which had an issue of blood twelve years,
²⁶ And had suffered many things of many physicians, and had spent all that she had, and was nothing bettered, but rather grew worse,
²⁷ When she had heard of Jesus, came in the press behind, and touched his garment.
²⁸ For she said, If I may touch but his clothes, I shall be whole.
²⁹ And straightway the fountain of her blood was dried up; and she felt in her body that she was healed of that plague.
³⁰ And Jesus, immediately knowing in himself that virtue had gone out of him, turned him about in the press, and said, **Who touched my clothes?**
³¹ And his disciples said unto him, Thou seest the multitude thronging thee, and sayest thou, Who touched me?
³² And he looked round about to see her that had done this thing.
³³ But the woman fearing and trembling, knowing what was done in her, came and fell down before him, and told him all the truth.
³⁴ And he said unto her, **Daughter, thy faith hath made thee whole; go in peace, and be whole of thy plague.**

She spent all that she had trying to be healed of **physicians**. She not only wasn’t healed of the physicians but she was **made worse** because of what they did. I have personally experienced this scenario. How many people do you know that are stuck going back to the doctors over and over and yet they still get worse? At that time those **physicians** would have also either been themselves an **apothecary** or consulted directly with **apothecaries** for potential cures. The modern equivalent of an apothecary is a **pharmacist**. How do pharmacists synthesis their drugs? Is it from plants, animals, and the environment just like every other **apothecary** in history?

What exactly is the deception in **Revelation 18:23**? Could it be that man can take care of himself and cure all of his ailments without God? In essence, “*ye shall be as gods*” (**Genesis 3:5**) which is **idolatry**.

* Strong’s Hebrew/Greek, being a dictionary, more often than not shows the most basic verb form of a word (actual Hebrew roots are unpronounceable). Because it is a dictionary it **does not even attempt** to precisely reflect the actual words used in God’s word in Hebrew and Greek. It focuses on the roots of the actual words and this is how we can see the plethora of connections to elsewhere in scripture, **not** because the exact same Hebrew word was used in two different places and then translated to two different English words. In other words, the words that you see in Strong’s concordance **are not** exactly the same as the words in God’s word. Therefore, it is more appropriate to refer to them as roots because the words in Strong’s are only part of the actual word forms that were used in God’s word. If you need proof of these facts there is a wide variety of it in the following article (and much more to be found by the studious reader): <https://cheerful-wmcdannell.wordpress.com/2026/02/17/the-dangers-of-relying-on-strongs-concordance-for-hebrew-greek-studies/>